

The White House: The Rooms Of Power [B2]

È uno dei monumenti più famosi al mondo, nonché residenza del Presidente degli Stati Uniti e della sua famiglia. Ecco com'è strutturato l'interno della Casa Bianca.

Sixteen hundred Pennsylvania Avenue, Washington is no common address. It is the seat of power of the United States of America and, some would say, of the free world. It is also the home of the president and his family. The White House has been the official residence of every president since the second, John Adams (1797-1801). As such, it is a museum of American history. Everyone knows what the White House looks like. Numerous films have shown the building being blown up by aliens or attacked by terrorists! But what is it really like inside?

THE RESIDENCE

The White House consists of a residence and two wings. The residence was designed by James Hoban and built in the neoclassical style between 1792 and 1800. It has 132 rooms and thirty-five bathrooms on six levels. There are eight staircases and three lifts. Starting at the bottom, the two-floor basement houses the equipment to run the White House, such as the air-conditioning, laundry and electrical controls. The ground floor connects to the East and West Wings. The South Portico is the entrance for foreign ambassadors, leading to the Diplomatic Reception Room. This floor also houses the Vermeil, China and Map Rooms, a florist, a carpenter's shop, a chocolate shop and rooms for the curator, doctor, housekeeper and the Secret Service. Last but not least, there is a bowling alley, right below the steps of the North Portico.

THE FIRST AND SECOND FLOORS

The North Portico is the entrance from street level to the first floor. Passing through the Cross and Entrance Halls, they lead straight to the Red, Blue and

Green rooms, which are decorated in those colours and are used as [parlours](#). The oval Blue Room is the most formal and has [stunning](#) views of the Washington Monument and Jefferson Memorial. It is also the home of the official White House Christmas tree. Elsewhere on the first floor, there is the [Ushers' Room](#), where guests check in, the East Room, for social functions, and the State Dining Room. The White House is able to serve dinner for 140 people! Finally, there is a smaller family dining room. The second floor is where the president and his family live. It has a dining room and kitchen, several bedrooms, a [sitting room](#), a study and the Yellow Oval Room, a formal living room used for receptions and meetings. The third floor is where the first family can relax, in the Sun Room, the Game Room, the [Work-Out Room](#) and the Music Room, added by Hilary Clinton as a gift to her husband.

THE WEST WING

To the sides of the residence are the two [wings](#): the East Wing and the West Wing. The West Wing [houses](#) the offices of the president and his staff on three floors. The basement has a [mess run](#) by the US Navy and rooms for Homeland Security and the Secret Service. The president can command the US forces from the Situation Room. It is where President Obama watched the [raid](#) on Osama Bin Laden's [compound](#) in 2011. The ground floor of the West Wing connects to the residence via the outdoor West [Colonnade](#). [Alongside](#) are the [Press Corps Offices](#) and the Press Briefing Room. Also on this floor are the building's entrance, the famous Oval Office, the Cabinet Room and individual offices for the president's staff. [Further offices](#) are located on the second floor. The Rose Garden sits outside the Oval office and the West Wing.

THE EAST WING

"If the West Wing is the mind of the nation, then the East Wing is the heart." So said [former](#) First Lady Betty Ford. Since the 1940s, it has housed the offices of the first lady and her staff, a symbol of her power and influence. Until recently, it also featured the Family Theater in the East [Colonnade](#) and

the Garden Room, which provided access to the Jacqueline Kennedy Garden. These have now been demolished to make room for a new state [ballroom](#). The East Wing is built on top of a secure bunker, known as the Presidential Emergency Operations Center (also featured in many Hollywood movies!) Built during World War Two, the bunker provides [shelter](#) for the president, his family and his staff. It contains a command centre, with full communications facilities. Most recently, President Trump was taken there during the Black Lives Matter protests on 31 May 2020, when protestors were chanting and throwing water bottles and other objects nearby. Laura Bush and the president's staff also stayed there after the 9/11 attacks. If you want to know more about this topic, read the articles [The Oval Office: The Most Famous Office In The World](#) and [White House Deluxe: Donald Trump Renovations Inc.](#)

Glossary

- **curator** = curatore (delle opere d'arte della Casa Bianca)
- **houses** = ospitare
- **parlours** = salotti
- **Work-Out Room** = palestra
- **run** = gestire
- **raid** = incursione
- **As such** = come tale
- **wings** = ali
- **laundry** = lavanderia
- **Last but not least** = ultimo ma non meno importante
- **blown up** = far saltare in aria
- **Alongside** = accanto
- **Further offices** = altri uffici
- **former** = ex
- **seat** = sede
- **two-floor basement** = seminterrato su due piani
- **bowling alley** = pista da bowling
- **stunning** = mozzafiato
- **sitting room** = salotto
- **compound** = complesso
- **staircases** = scale
- **lifts** = ascensori
- **Starting at the bottom** = iniziando dal basso
- **housekeeper** = governante
- **Ushers' Room** = sala degli uscieri
- **ballroom** = sala da ballo
- **mess** = mensa
- **Colonnade** = colonnato
- **Press Corps Offices** = uffici della stampa
- **shelter** = rifugio